Striped Bass Are in Trouble, and Anglers Are Worried

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Bill Jakob has fished for striped bass for more than 60 years. Near Montauk, New York, he once caught eight or nine fish up to 40 pounds. Now he and many East Coast **anglers** worry because the fish are not showing up as often, and young fish are harder to find.

Scientists agree. **Regulators** said last week the fish have had eight years of poor **reproduction** in Chesapeake Bay. Heavy fishing is only part of the problem; warming water, low river flow, drought, pollution, and possibly more seals and sharks may make recovery harder.

Up to 90 percent **spawn** and grow there. They do best in cool, wet springs, but since 2019 low flows and high temperatures have meant fewer young fish.

Striped bass are prized from Maine to Florida. Industry members say fishing adds about $8 billion and as many as 100,000 jobs. **Regulators** have not cut **recreational** catch levels, but some fishermen say a temporary pause like one in the 1980s may be needed. Experts and **anglers** agree the fish are not replacing themselves fast enough.

Word Treasure

anglers -- People who fish with a rod and line for fun or sport.

reproduction -- When animals have babies so there are more of them.

Regulators -- People in charge of making and enforcing rules about fishing.

spawn -- When fish lay eggs in the water.

recreational -- Done for fun rather than as a job.

Background you need

Striped bass are fish that live along the East Coast and spawn in Chesapeake Bay, where many of their young grow up.

They do best in cool, wet springs, when river water helps young fish survive and grow.

When the water gets warmer, river flow drops, and fishing stays heavy, fewer young fish are born, so the fish cannot replace themselves fast enough.

Break it down

WHO: Bill Jakob, many East Coast anglers, scientists, experts, and regulators concerned about striped bass

WHAT: Striped bass are not showing up as often and young fish are harder to find after eight years of poor reproduction

WHERE: Chesapeake Bay, where up to 90 percent spawn and grow, and waters from Maine to Florida, including near Montauk, New York

WHY: Heavy fishing is only part of the problem, along with warming water, low river flow, drought, pollution, and possibly more seals and sharks, with low flows and high temperatures since 2019

Why it matters

If striped bass keep becoming harder to find, a child's fishing trip with family could end with far fewer fish to catch and enjoy.

Test what you remember

1. **How long has Bill Jakob fished for striped bass?**
   - (A) Less than 5 years
   - (B) About 10 years
   - (C) More than 60 years
   - (D) About 25 years
2. **Near which place did Bill Jakob once catch eight or nine fish up to 40 pounds?**
   - (A) In Maine
   - (B) In Florida
   - (C) Near Montauk, New York
   - (D) In Chesapeake Bay
3. **According to regulators, how many years of poor reproduction have the fish had in Chesapeake Bay?**
   - (A) Eight years
   - (B) Sixty years
   - (C) Two years
   - (D) Twenty years
4. **Up to what share of striped bass spawn and grow in Chesapeake Bay?**
   - (A) Up to 25 percent
   - (B) Up to 50 percent
   - (C) Up to 10 percent
   - (D) Up to 90 percent
5. **Since 2019, what has meant fewer young fish?**
   - (A) Cool, wet springs
   - (B) A temporary pause
   - (C) Low flows and high temperatures
   - (D) More fishing boats alone
6. **What do some fishermen say may be needed?**
   - (A) No change at all
   - (B) A permanent end to all fishing
   - (C) Higher catch levels
   - (D) A temporary pause like one in the 1980s

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. East Coast anglers: They worry because the fish are not showing up as often and young fish are harder to find.
2. Some fishermen: They say a temporary pause like one in the 1980s may be needed.
3. Industry members: They say fishing adds about $8 billion and as many as 100,000 jobs.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):